Ben Kawam

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Appointments

April 2026 - *Present*
Postdoctoral researcher
Max Planck Institute of Animal Behavior, Germany

May 2025 - Dec 2025
Resident Fellow
Konrad Lorenz Institute for Evolution and Cognition Research, Austria

Education

Apr 2022 - Dec 2025
Ph.D. in Behavioural Ecology
German Primate Center; *University of Göttingen*, Germany
Summa cum laude (defence); Magna cum laude (dissertation).

Sept 2019 - Nov 2021
M.Sc. Erasmus Mundus Master Programme in Evolutionary Biology
University of Groningen, Netherlands; *University of Montpellier*, France
Cum laude.

Sept 2016 - Jun 2019
B.Sc. in Biology, focus on Organismal Biology and Ecology
University of Namur, Belgium
Summa cum laude.

Jan 2019 - Jun 2019
Exchange semester
Uppsala University, Sweden

Publications

* *indicates joint first authorship.*

2025 — **Kawam, B.**, McElreath R., Ostner, J., Redhead, D. & Schülke, O., (2025). Inferring the causes of animal social network structure from time-series data. *biorXiv*.

2025 — Redhead, D.*, **Kawam, B.***, Young, J.-G., Franks, D., Philson, C. S., van Duijn, M., Hart, J., McElreath, M. B., McElreath, R., Power, E. A., Ross, C., Sosa, S., Steglich, C., Weiss, M., & Brent, L. J. N. (2025). Five misunderstandings in animal social network analysis. *EcoEvoRxiv*.

2024 — **Kawam, B.**, Ostner, J., McElreath R., Schülke, O., & Redhead, D. (2025). A causal framework for animal social network structure. *PLOS Computational Biology*.

2020 — Biwer, C.*, **Kawam, B.***, Chapelle, V., & Silvestre, F. (2020). The role of stochasticity in the origin of epigenetic variation in animal populations. *Integrative and Comparative Biology*, 60(6), 1544-1557.

Grants and Awards

2026 — Inaugural Seed Grant (4,700 USD), Max Planck – Smithsonian Center for Sensory Ecology and Social Evolution (co-recipient). Project: *Modelling the time-varying causes of animal social network structure*.

Commendation Award, SORTEE. Awarded to the *EvoBio Crash Course* (co-recipient).

2022	*IDEA Initiative Grant* (25,000 USD), SMBE. Awarded to the *EvoBio Crash Course* (co-recipient).
2021	Best Presentation, 2021 PSGB Winter Meeting.
	Equal Opportunities Initiative Fund (1,000 EUR), ESEB. Awarded to the *EvoBio Crash Course* (co-recipient).
	Erasmus+ Traineeship Grant (5,000 EUR), funded by the EU.
2019	Erasmus+ Mobility Grant (2,000 EUR), funded by the EU.

Talks and Workshops

	Kawam, B., & Redhead, D. *Animal Social Network Analysis* (150 min).
2026	Pre-conference workshop. *EFP 2026, Montpellier, France.*
	The causal analysis of animal social networks.
2026	Invited speaker. *CRAB, Exeter, UK.*
2025	Invited speaker. *Department for the Ecology of Animal Societies, MPI-AB, Konstanz, Germany.*
	Kawam, B., McElreath R., Ostner, J., Redhead, D. & Schülke, O., *Inferring the causes of animal social network structure from time-series data.*
2026	Conference contribution. *ISBE 2026, Turin, Italy.*
2025	Invited speaker. *Department of Sociology, University of Groningen, Netherlands.*
	Kawam, B., Ostner, J., McElreath R., Schülke, O., & Redhead, D. *A causal framework for animal social network structure.*
2024	Conference contribution. *EHBEA 2024, Montpellier, France.*
	Invited speaker. *Department of Sociology, University of Groningen, Netherlands.*
2023	Conference contribution. *Behaviour 2023, Bielefeld, Germany.*
	Kawam, B., Ostner, J., McElreath R., Schülke, O., & Redhead, D. *Personality and social relationships in animal social networks.*
2023	Colloquium. *BeCog summer colloquium, Göttingen, Germany.*
	Invited speaker at the *MARM* group meeting, *GELIFES, University of Groningen.*
	Kawam, B., Huchard, E., Cowlishaw, G., & Carter, A. J. *Health costs and benefits of social connectedness for wild baboons.*
2021	Conference contribution. *PSGB 2021 Winter meeting.*

Technical Skills

Modeling	Probabilistic and causal modeling.
Programming	R, Stan, GitHub, HTML & CSS.
Fieldwork	Sampling of behavioural, ecological, and spatial data; basic field management.
Illustration	Adobe Illustrator, TikZ.
Writing	LaTeX, Quarto/R Markdown, Microsoft Office.

Teaching and Supervision

	Introduction to Causal Inference and Directed Acyclic Graphs (30-120 min talk).
2025	Lecturer for *Linear models and their application*, designed for graduate students & faculty.
2024	Given to PhD students of the *BeCog* doctoral program of the University of Göttingen.
	Lecturer for *Linear models and their application*, designed for graduate students & faculty.
2023	Tutorial given to *BeCog* PhD students.
2022	*Getting Started with GitHub* (30 min talk)
	Tutorial given to *BeCog* PhD students.
	Supervision of Lena Lindner, a M.Sc. student at the University of Göttingen, for a 10 weeks project.

Reviewer Experience

Scientific Journals
Biological Reviews
Methods in Ecology and Evolution
Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B

Related Experience

Mar 2022 - *Present*	**Web Designer at Evolutionary Biology Crash Course** Co-responsible for Web Design, Graphic Design and Outreach.
2019 - *Present*	**Scientific Illustrator** Creation of scientific illustrations and logos. Examples *here*.
Jul 2018 - Aug 2018	**Intern at Tacugama Chimpanzee Sanctuary, Sierra Leone** Behavioural observations; animal care; logistic support; outreach.
Jul 2017 - Aug 2017	**Intern at Cikananga Wildlife Sanctuary, Indonesia** Behavioural observations; animal care; logistic support; outreach.
Oct 2015 - Jan 2016	**Volunteer at Gibbon Rehabilitation Center, Thailand** Outreach; animal care; gibbon tracking.

References

Prof. Dr. Richard McElreath
Director
Department of Human Behaviour, Ecology & Culture, Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology
Deutscher Platz 6, 04103 Leipzig, Germany
Relationship to applicant: Co-supervisor of PhD thesis
Email: richard_mcelreath@eva.mpg.de

Dr. Daniel J. Redhead
Assistant Professor in Sociology
Department of Sociology/ICS, University of Groningen
Grote Rozenstraat 31, 9712 TG Groningen, The Netherlands
Relationship to applicant: Co-supervisor of PhD thesis
Email: d.j.redhead@rug.nl

Dr. Brendan J. Barrett
Group Leader

Department for the Ecology of Animal Societies, Max Planck Institute of Animal Behavior
Bücklestraße 5, 78467 Konstanz, Germany
Relationship to applicant: Group leader
Email: bbarrett@ab.mpg.de

Dr. Oliver Schülke
Senior Scientist
Department for Behavioural Ecology, University of Göttingen
Kellnerweg 6, D-37077 Göttingen, Germany
Relationship to applicant: Co-supervisor of PhD thesis
Email: oliver.Schuelke@biologie.uni-goettingen.de